has in large measure persisted until the present. It was only the rise of a number of independent states in Central and Eastern Europe after World War I that, as we will see in Chapter 6, began to change this picture. Unfortunately, Yalta and the Iron Curtain cemented this view for another 50 years.

Western writers during the period of Ottoman rule in south-east Europe found a particular satisfaction in their discovery of these lands, either in reality (by means of travel) or in imagination. 'Eastern Europe' in those times could mean the Ottoman-occupied lands of south-east Europe or what I have called 'Eastern Europe proper'. There was not a clear definition, nor was there a need for one. The Oriental elements of the Ottoman Empire inspired as much fear as fascination, and both feelings informed views of the countries beyond the 'Iron Curtain' of the time. Facts about these countries did not really matter as much as the imagination. The alleged ferocity of the bloodthirsty Ottomans, which began to be associated with the lands beyond the Curtain, somehow impressed the Western world. The Dracula character stems from this source. In modern times it has been revisited by comparable works of fiction. A similar contemporary stereotype was created by Hollywood in the 2005 film *Hostel* in which two naïve American students, seeking sex and drugs, end up in a torture chamber in Slovakia. Stereotypes can be reinforced by movies from Eastern Europe itself. After the screening in a Dutch cinema of a Bosnian movie about the dilemmas of a group of desperate and lonely women in a remote village, a Bosnian lady said to me: 'This is the picture the people of Western Europe want to have about us: poor and nice. It is a strange sort of comfort for a Dutchman leaving the cinema and thinking, "Thank God I am not Bosnian! We may be in the midst of a global financial crisis but I will be looked after; my comfortable life as a European citizen will not be disrupted that greatly. I will not be left to my own destiny and to the elements somewhere up in the Bosnian hills with no future to look forward to".'

The fall of the Berlin Wall revived the fascination of the Western world with the East, in a mixture of disdain, naivety, envy and self-indulgence. The poverty of the East has been a confirmation of Western high standards of living and the idealised primordial warmth of the East, a nostalgic reminder of social conditions it has long lost.